

THE CERAMIC CANVAS: TRACING THE EPIGRAPHIC AND SOCIOLINGUISTIC EVOLUTION OF THE TAMIL SCRIPT

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Abstract

This paper examines the evolutionary trajectory of southern Indian writing systems from their proto-historical origins to their modern standardized forms. By analyzing the transition from non-phonetic Kuriyeedu (graffiti symbols) to the highly specialized allophonic orthography of Tamizhi (Tamil-Brahmi), the study explores a long-term continuum of literacy and symbolic communication in peninsular India. Particular attention is given to structural adaptations that emerged across Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana in response to linguistic, material, and administrative pressures. The paper further investigates the impact of Grantha, Manipravalam, and regional political developments on script diversification, including the emergence of Malayalam and the Kannada-Telugu script continuum. Finally, the study demonstrates how ancient practices of symbolic identification continue to find parallels in contemporary domestic labelling and organizational systems.

Keywords: Tamizhi, Kuriyeedu, Tamil-Brahmi, Indus Valley Civilisation, Bhattiprolu, Kadamba Script, Grantha, Script Evolution, Dravidian Languages.

1. Introduction

The evolution of writing systems in southern India has often been interpreted through models that emphasise derivation from northern Brahmi traditions. While the influence of Brahmi remains an important component of South Asian epigraphy, archaeological discoveries and linguistic research increasingly suggest that the southern peninsula possessed its own complex traditions of symbolic communication and script adaptation (Mahadevan, 2014; Salomon, 1998).

This study examines the development of southern writing systems from early graffiti symbols to historically attested alphabets. By exploring the relationship between Kuriyeedu, Tamizhi, Bhattiprolu, Kadamba, Grantha, and later regional scripts, the paper argues that orthographic evolution in southern India was shaped not only by linguistic requirements but also by geography, political authority, and writing materials. The result was not a single linear tradition but a network of related script cultures that adapted to distinct regional circumstances (Krishnamurti, 2003).

2. Discussion

2.1 The Silent Origins: Kuriyeedu and the Indus Connection

Prior to the emergence of formal phonetic alphabets, systems of visual identification played an important role in communication, ownership marking, and symbolic representation. In southern India, these markings are commonly referred to as Kuriyeedu or graffiti symbols. Archaeological excavations at sites such as Keezhadi, Thulukarpatti, and Kodumanal have revealed numerous examples engraved on pottery fragments, cave surfaces, and other material objects (Rajan & Sivananthan, 2024).

Several researchers have observed notable morphological correspondences between recurring Kuriyeedu motifs and signs documented within the Indus script corpus (Balakrishnan, 2021; Rajan & Sivananthan, 2024). While the nature of this relationship remains debated and no scholarly consensus exists regarding direct continuity, these similarities have generated significant interest in discussions concerning long-term cultural transmission between northwestern and southern regions of the subcontinent.

Following the decline of urban centers associated with the Indus Valley Civilization during the second millennium BCE, various models propose the movement of populations, cultural practices, and symbolic traditions into other regions of South Asia (Balakrishnan, 2021). Within this framework, Kuriyeedu may be understood as part of a broader visual tradition that persisted independently of later phonetic writing systems.

The functional role of these symbols extended beyond symbolism alone. In domestic contexts, markings served as identifiers for ownership and organization. Comparable practices continue today through the labelling of household items, educational materials, and storage containers. Although separated by millennia, both systems reflect similar cognitive approaches to classification and material organization.

2.2 The Linguistic Engineering of Tamizhi

As spoken Tamil developed greater phonological complexity, non-phonetic symbols became insufficient for representing linguistic information. This transition facilitated the emergence of Tamizhi, commonly referred to in modern scholarship as Tamil-Brahmi (Mahadevan, 2014).

Although often classified as a southern adaptation of Brahmi, Tamizhi exhibits significant structural modifications tailored to the phonological requirements of Old Tamil. Unlike northern Brahmi traditions, which maintained separate characters for aspirated and voiced consonants, Tamizhi adopted an allophonic orthographic framework in which pronunciation was largely determined by phonological context rather than character inventory (Mahadevan, 2014; Krishnamurti, 2003).

This system allowed a relatively compact alphabet to represent a wide range of phonetic realisations. Furthermore, scholars developed unique graphemes to represent sounds characteristic of Muthozhi languages, including ழ (Zha), ற (Ra), and ன (Na), which lacked direct equivalents in northern writing systems (Mahadevan, 2014).

The visual appearance of Tamizhi also reflected its material environment. Characters were generally angular and linear, making them suitable for inscription on stone surfaces and pottery.

2.3 Epigraphic Divergence in the Greater Deccan

While Tamil-speaking regions preserved a largely allophonic orthographic framework, different trajectories emerged across the Deccan plateau. In modern Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana, script development occurred within multilingual environments characterised by interactions among Dravidian languages, Prakriti, and later Sanskrit traditions (Salomon, 1998).

One of the earliest examples of regional adaptation is the Bhattiprolu script of Andhra Pradesh. Dating from approximately the third to first centuries BCE, this writing system introduced structural modifications that distinguished it from Ashokan Brahmi and improved its suitability for local linguistic requirements (Bühler, 1894; Sarma, 1992).

In Karnataka, script development accelerated under the Kadamba dynasty, whose inscriptions demonstrate the emergence of what is often termed the Kadamba script or Pre-Old-Kannada (Salomon, 1998). Over subsequent centuries, the script evolved through the administrative traditions of the Chalukyas and Rashtrakutas, eventually forming the basis of the shared Kannada-Telugu script continuum.

By approximately the tenth century CE, this common script tradition gradually diverged into the distinct modern scripts associated with Kannada and Telugu. Despite later differentiation, both systems retain evidence of their shared historical foundations (Krishnamurti, 2003).

2.4 Grantha, Manipravalam, and Regional Divergence

The introduction of Sanskrit into administrative, religious, and literary domains created new orthographic challenges throughout southern India. To accommodate Sanskrit phonology, scribes increasingly employed the Grantha script, which possessed the expanded consonantal inventory necessary for representing aspirated sounds absent from native Dravidian systems (Salomon, 1998).

This interaction encouraged the development of Manipravalam, a hybrid literary tradition combining Sanskrit lexical items with local grammatical structures. Palm-leaf manuscripts frequently display alternating script usage, reflecting the coexistence of multiple linguistic traditions within the same textual environment.

Regional responses to this development differed significantly. In Kerala, sustained interaction between Grantha and Vatteluttu contributed to the gradual emergence of the Malayalam script. In Tamil Nadu, however, scribes largely preserved the existing orthographic framework while incorporating a limited set of Grantha-derived characters to represent external loanwords (Mahadevan, 2014).

These divergent responses illustrate how script evolution was shaped not only by language contact but also by regional political and cultural preferences.

2.5 Material Evolution into Modern Tamil Script

Changes in writing materials significantly influenced orthographic design. As palm-leaf manuscripts became the dominant medium for literary production, angular strokes posed practical challenges because they could damage the writing surface.

To accommodate this material constraint, scribes increasingly adopted curved and rounded forms that reduced the likelihood of tearing palm leaves. This process contributed to the development of Vatteluttu and other rounded writing traditions (Mahadevan, 2014).

Subsequent developments associated with printing technologies, educational standardisation, and digital typography further transformed these historical forms into the modern Tamil script used today. Despite these changes, many structural features of the earlier writing traditions remain recognizable within contemporary orthography.

3. Conclusion

The history of southern Indian writing systems demonstrates that script evolution is inseparable from linguistic structure, material technology, and political context. From the symbolic markings of Kuriyeedu to the allophonic precision of Tamizhi and the regional diversification of Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam, each stage reflects an adaptive response to changing communicative needs.

Rather than representing passive borrowings from external traditions, southern scripts emerged through continuous processes of modification, innovation, and regional specialization. The preservation of distinctive Dravidian phonological features, alongside adaptations to new administrative and literary environments, underscores the dynamic nature of orthographic development.

Ultimately, the southern script traditions reveal how writing systems function not merely as tools of communication but as enduring records of cultural adaptation and historical continuity.

4. References

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